systems. The internal debate over whether to expand the efforts to build nuclear capability as well continued for a long time. The initial position of the first spiritual leader, Khomeini, based, inter alia, on religious grounds, was to rule out nuclear development. Later on, however, he was brought around by the proponents of nuclear development, headed by members of IRGC, and he gave his blessing for the launching of a development program.

One can assume that over the course of the discussions the question arose as to whether Iran should build up its military capabilities only to deal with the Iraqi threat in the future or whether it should build strategic capabilities that would support a foreign policy that aspired to turn Iran into a regional hegemon.

In any case, the second position was the one that was adopted, and Iran embarked on an arms race with long-term plans and budgets and with deceptive plots for the concealment of its programs to obtain military nuclear capability, long-range missile capability, and chemical and biological military capabilities. Later, submarines were added to the list.

The first proof of the new Iranian strategic doctrine made its way to Israel when intelligence was received indicating that the Iranians were extending the range of the Shihab 3 missile, the first to be developed under the new doctrine, to 1,300 kilometers. This range covered the entire State of Israel with launchers stationed in western Iran. Today they have missiles with a range that allows them to place the launchers deep inside Iran and still cover the entire State of Israel. During the first half of the 1990s, ample evidence of Iran’s activity to realize its strategic capabilities accumulated, with a central element of this evidence being its intensive acquisition of Western technologies.

The Israeli quest to convince the world that Iran’s ambition was to become a military hegemon in the Middle East began in 1991. I remember how I would go from country to country, from the head of one intelligence agency to the next, from one military commander to another and from one decision maker to another, trying to convince them that a strategic threat was developing against Israel, one that would also constitute a regional threat. I must say that at first I was taken for a lunatic. Later, I would receive the response, “Leave us alone, you’re talking about a threat that’s way off in the distance— we’re busy dealing with a long list of more urgent threats.”